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A Maritime Sociology for Sustainability Science

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Abstract

Sustainability science emphasizes interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary research. However, several authors argue that sociology remains underutilized, despite its potential to significantly improve our understanding of the human-nature relationship and social change processes. This has been changing in recent years, with more attention directed to maritime social sciences, especially after the MARE 2019 conference. Academic production in different social sciences regarding maritime issues has been intensively developing. In this article we first assess the current position of sociology within the subfield of maritime social sciences. We found that sociology lags in its engagement in social maritime research and provide a possible explanation related to the classical disciplinary distinction between modernity and tradition. Second, we describe the recent discussions on a possible new "maritime sociology" subfield. Finally, we discuss the potential contributions of sociology's disciplinary toolbox (agency, institutions, social change, social fields) to transitions to sustainability.

Keywords: Maritime sociology, Social Change, Sustainability transitions, Sustainability science

1. Introduction

Sustainability science emerged as a broad, multidisciplinary field defined more by its purpose than by a specific set of disciplines. This solution-oriented interdisciplinary field [1,2] focuses on the intricate interactions between nature and society, aiming to guide us towards sustainable development [3]. Considering the complex nature of the problems that sustainability science aims to provide solutions (ocean acidification, air pollution, overexploitation of natural resources) the need for interdisciplinary and transdisciplinary work becomes urgent, since such deep and wide-scoping problems require perspectives, theoretical tools, frameworks and methodologies from environmental science, engineering, economy, social sciences and others. Researchers emphasize the need for stronger integration between social and natural sciences, as both explore the reciprocal relationships between social and environmental change [4,5]. Further underscored by the UN's "decade of action", achieving sustainable development requires a fundamental transformation of social structures, institutions, and regulations currently hindering the process [6]. However, not all social science disciplines have been equally utilized [7]. Despite the development of environmental sociology since the 1970s [8], sociological tools remain underutilized within sustainability research [9].

Several authors have noticed this less protagonic role of sociology and have called for a deeper involvement of sociologists into sustainability research [9–11]. Recent literature highlights the contributions of sociology's theoretical and methodological toolbox for sustainability and transitions to sustainability. And among those who are discussing the role of sociology in environmental and sustainability issues, many have raised a voice specifically concerning the marine environment [12–14]. It has been observed that the marine ecosystem has been mostly ignored by sociology [9,10], in fact, Cocco [15] emphasizes this by quoting Taussig "sea has been disappearing from our minds". Scholars attribute this lack of attention to the misconception of the ocean as limitless or "too big to fail" [16,17]. This idea has been removed given the increasing evidence of the dire consequences of anthropogenic causes of ocean acidification, pollution, overfishing and rising ocean temperature [16,17]. This is evidence of the importance of social relationships and institutions in providing agreements that contribute to solving these negative consequences [13]. This was key for the emergence of the Manifesto for marine social sciences in the MARE (center for maritime research) 2019 Conference which states that mitigation and adaptation to climate change must be priorities

in research since the large-scale event has the possibility of "drowning" human development concerns [12]. This acknowledgement of social relations "with the sea" has boosted the development of marine social sciences post-MARE 2019 Conference [18–21].

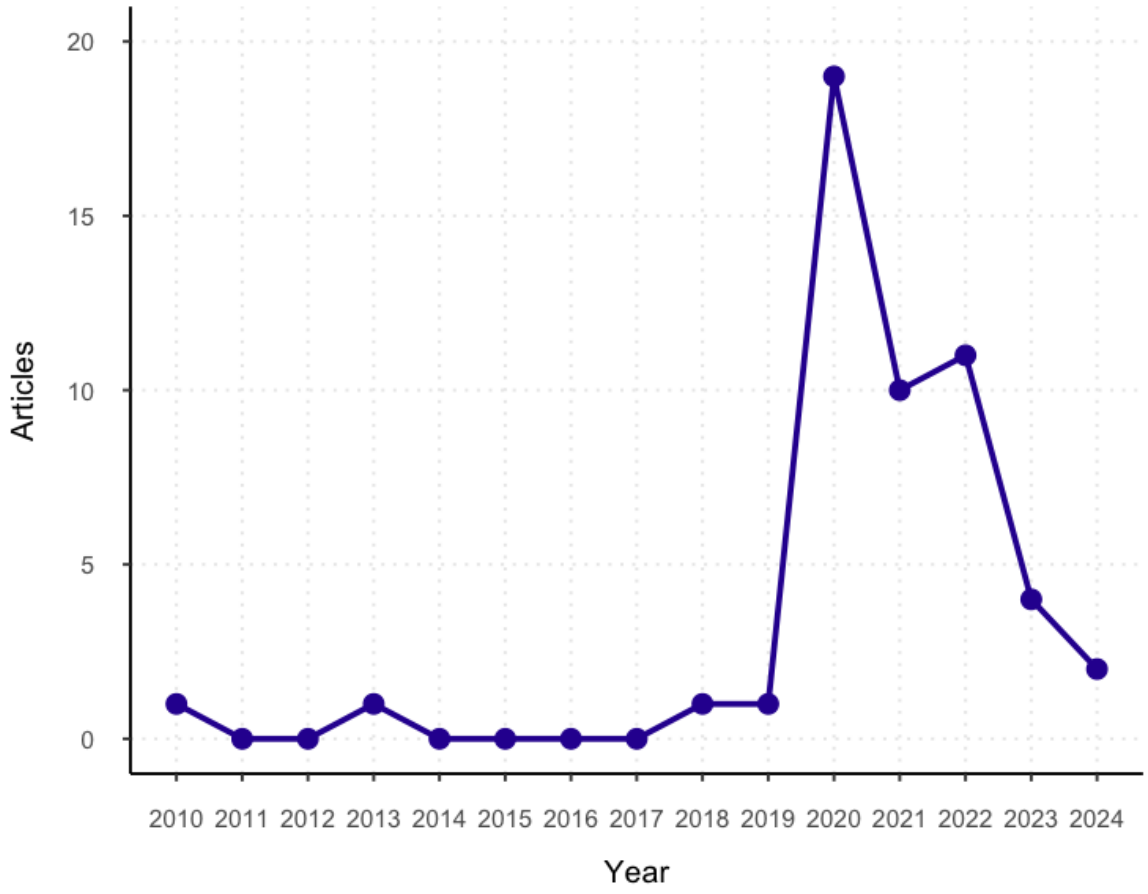
In this context and in line with the Decade of Action to deliver the Sustainable Development Goals, is where we present this current opinion. We argue that sociology has a robust theoretical and empirical set of tools to study agency, social change, institutionality, governance and more that can contribute to sustainability transitions [22], specifically in the marine environment and thus, we aim to contribute to the development of a distinctive subfield within this discipline, "maritime sociology". We reflect on the links between sustainability science and sociology emphasizing the contributions of this discipline towards more sustainability of maritime governance. This current opinion highlights that a possible maritime sociology based on an object of study (the sea, oceans, the coast), rather than relationships that unfold within it, is insufficient. This implies recognizing the transdisciplinarity of such relationships and acknowledging the political nature of maritime governance, which aligns it with sustainability science.

We performed a literature review in three steps, each one aligned with one specific objective. Our first objective was to analyze the position of sociology in the field of maritime social science. We searched the Scopus and WOS (core collection) databases using the terms "marine social sciences" (TITLE-ABS-KEY). The results were 22 documents in WOS (from 2019 to 2024) and 47 in SCOPUS (2010 to 2024) (the timeframe was not modified). We used the "bibliometrix" package (version 4.2.0) in R (version 4.3.2) to remove duplicates, 50 documented were included. For our second objective, we focused on identifying efforts to establish maritime sociology as a distinct subfield, rather than studies simply applying sociological tools to marine study objects (though we acknowledge their importance). Our search strategy was ("maritime sociology" OR "marine sociology" OR "blue sociology" OR "sociology of oceans" OR "sociology of the sea" OR "sociology of fish*" OR "fish* sociology" (TITLE-ABS-KEY). This search identified 19 articles in Scopus. In the WOS database, 10 documents were retrieved, from 1978 to 2022 (WOS core collection). After removing duplicates with the same R package, a total of 20 documents were included. The documents resulting from the first and second steps were analyzed through the following questions: how sociology has been contributing to research on marine space? What are the latest discussions on the subfield of marine sociology? Finally, we reflect on the contributions of sociology to sustainability science and transitions to sustainability.

2. The current position of sociology in the study of the sea

When considering the problems associated with the Anthropocene, it becomes more necessary to consider the social challenges related to the marine [7]. In consequence, calls have been made for social sciences to better integrate to marine research. Historically, social sciences have been contributing to marine research since the 1960 decade, especially ethnological studies on communities of artisanal fishers [23]. In the last few years, "marine social sciences" has been evolving post MARE 2019 conference [Figure 1]. However, from the 50 documents analyzed, only one document makes an explicit mention to sociology in the abstract.

Figure 1: Academic production of marine social sciences.

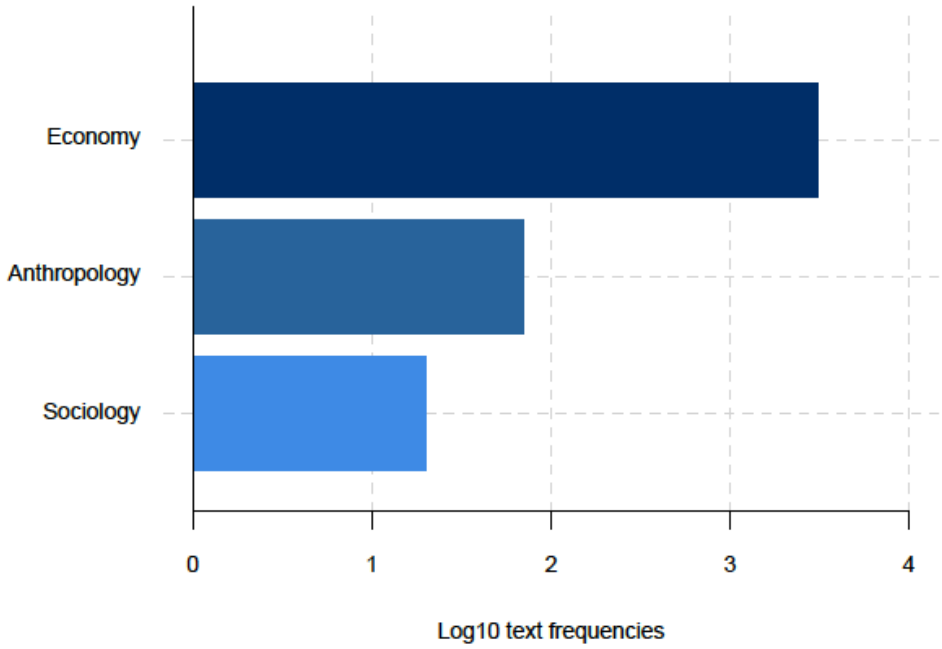


Note: This is the results of the search strategy "marine social sciences" (TITLE-ABS-KEY) in WOS and Scopus. The timeframe was not modified.

When trying to explain the scarce and recent academic production of sociological research on maritime issues, specifically as a research subfield, contrary to the emergence of subfields in economy and

anthropology [Figure 2], some authors argue that sociology has been conceived and self-perceived as terrestrial, with social relationships and social institutions placed on the ground and where the social relationships and institutions placed on the maritime environment are just an extension of terrestrial relations and social institutions [10,24,25]. In this view, core sociological concepts such as social action, structure, agency, social relationships are just extended to the sea, thus, there is nothing specific about what happens to fishers, seafarers, marine crew members experience when sailing, similar to the critique of human exceptionalism from environmental studies [26].

Figure 2: Number of publications within maritime subfield in sociology, economy, and anthropology



Note: Based on the results from WOS and Scopus using the search strategy: “maritime sociology” OR “marine sociology” OR “blue sociology” OR “sociology of the oceans” OR “sociology of the sea” OR “sociology of the fish*” OR “fish* sociology”. Then, for “economics” and “anthropology”, the terms were replaced. This search strategy intended to integrate closely related terms like “fisher*” or “maritime”. After deleting duplicates in both databases, the results were: 20 documents for sociology, anthropology 70 and 3117 in economics. This graph was made in $\log 10$ to better represent the differences.

Under this dominant view that sociology is a discipline that deals with issues linked to the ground, to terrestrial problems, this has resulted in a lack of research on maritime issues [25]. We want to contribute

to this literature by arguing that, in addition to this implicit view of sociology as a terrestrial discipline (what Driessen calls "the terracentric bias", another reason stems from the original concern of sociology, the distinction between tradition and modernity. Within the sea and the social relationships that are deployed on the sea are associated with traditional societies (artisanal fishers and divers as hunter-gatherers, for instance) [27]. Classical contributions to sociology such as Marx and Engels, influenced by evolutionary perspectives of XIX century, view marine activity as a previous moment of human development, unconnected with the modern features of economic production [28]. This view re-introduces the disciplinary arrangements of the early XX century where sociology focused on modernity (industrialization, urbanization, work division, the modern State, representative democracy, capitalism) and anthropology to traditional societies [29]. This explains a rich body of anthropology research on maritime activities, as it is the case of fishing, but not in sociology [30].

2.1. In search of a maritime sociology

This debate on the sub-utilization of sociology in marine research and sustainability has fostered debate among sociologists on the different approaches to this issue (a marine sociology or sociology of oceans, a new subfield, or a research panorama, and so on). Some attempts to systemize a marine sociology first started in Poland, during the 1960 and 1970 decades. These efforts to avoid terracentrism in the discipline [31] by recognizing sociologists contributions to build a possible maritime sociology [32], some of which re-discovered the work of Norbert Elias [33] and Ludwik Janiszewski's concept of "maritimization" (the social impacts of the sea) in the field of global relation [34,35], and contribute an ontological and epistemological reflection on the sea and oceans, labeled "blue turn" or "oceanic turn" [8,36,37]. Notably, Poland has actively developed maritime sociology (heavily influenced by Janiszewski), even establishing a dedicated journal called "Annal of Maritime Sociology" (Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej). As the concept started relatively new, its development has been concentrated in Great Britain, Scandinavian countries, China, and Eastern Europe [14,25,38].

Another attempt to establish a subfield within sociology was made by Poole, he exposed a manifesto on specific topics and paradigms of this supposed subfield of sociology, within the context of the current theories of his time. Among the subjects that this author highlighted we can find: The distinction between community (Gemeinschaft) and association (Gesellschaft); subjective forces that configure action; the study of guidelines of differentiation and stratification of fishers; the use of the concept of "total institution" for an analysis of life on boats and ships, topics that are currently being studied and published today [33];

social change derived from endogenous and exogenous forces (politics, legal, economic, social). It is important to note that Poole didn't draw conclusions on this new sociology subfield, rather he was limited to give indications about new empirical research and theoretical reflections on marine sociology [14]. Since then, plenty of researchers, with certain conceptual divergence, have been pushing for academic production, as well as academic events and congresses aiming to establish and consolidate this subfield.

Up to date "marine sociology" still has a small corpus of literature, since maritime issues have been approached from other areas of sociological research where sociologist had applied some social notions such as power and institutionality to the governance of fisheries resources. The main authors that have been discussing this issue such as Longo, Cocco, Hannigan among others, have also been summarizing, discussing, and recalling the contributions of sociology to marine research. We can call the contributions of Jentoft [13] to the study of the relationship between marine resources management and governance of human behavior, as well as a deeper understanding on small-scale fisheries as part of a unique social and cultural experience [13]. Some have been applying the Goffman concept of "total institution" to study the intricacies of human life inside ships, noting that social relationships on the sea are unique and not an extension of terrestrial social relationships [39]. Other applied contributions of sociology to maritime issues are the actor-network theory [40], the application of theory of social practices [27], analysis of the effects of neoliberal politics of privatization and deregulation of marine resources [41], and most recently, theories of gender to coastal and fisheries management [42,43], resource management and social organization through social network analysis [44] and the struggles between agents in the fisheries space for resource capture [45], social metabolic analysis applied to climate change, ocean acidification and pollution [10], new frameworks integrating the "social" to fisheries management [46] among others. We summarize those contributions and many others in Table 1.

Table 1.

Some analytical and methodological tools of sociology to study of sea or ocean or fisheries

Theoretical or methodological contribution	Main researchers	Brief description

Actor-Network theory	Callon [40]; Lehman [47]; Yao and Liu [48]; Bartłomiejski and Kowalewski [49].	Integrate non-human agency. Intersection of phenomena from different nature such as ecological or social in dialogue with maritime agents.
Network social analysis	Bodin and Crona [50]; Crona, Gelcich and Bodin [44]; Jariego [51].	Study the structure of social relations and maritime agents. Integrate a methodology to study social capital and its relationship with economic and productive performance.
Practice Theory	Pálsson [27,52]; Brulle & Norgaard [53]; Zhen, Yinji & Yue [38].	Contributes with a way of study bodily disposition and learning way of agents involved in the sea.
Effects of neoliberal policies	Bresnihan [54]; Knott and Neis [41]; Pinkerton and Davis [55].	Research line linked to the "tragedy of the commons" and the contributions of Elinor Ostrom. Opposed to ideas of market efficiency in open marine resource management.
Dramaturgy and interactionism	Popović [39]; Poole [56]; Simons [57]	Application of Goffman theory of total institution to the social relations placed on boats and ships.
Feminism and gender studies	Frangoudes [58]; Gustavsson [43,59,60]; Galappaththi [61];	Earlier studies focused on the invisibilization of women working on the marine space. Currently research vindicate the role of women.
Social fields theory and conflict between marine agents	Kungl and Hess [22]; Olsson, and Jerneck [5], Bavinck, Jentoft & Scholtens [45]; Galappaththi, [61].	Recent theoretical application that highlights the relationships between marine agents, as part of a constant struggle for positions of power and control over the rules of the field.
Blue justice and values	Bennett and others [42,62], Ertör [63].	Within discussion on "blue economy", contributions emerge that highlight inequalities and the values that capitalist economy produces inside the marine space.
Analytical elements applied to globalization.	Wozniak [64], Ballinger [65].	Several contributions from postmodernist and posthumanism approaches (Risk society Beck, Bauman liquid society, Luhman systemic approach, Urry mobility, etc.).
Sociology of organization and work	Wegenschimmel [66]; Kołodziej & Kołodziej-Durnaś [67]; Kołodziej-Durnaś [68]	Studies in the workplace. Industrialization and transformations of the naval industry. Organizational changes due to economic transformation.

Port cities	Kowalewski [69]; Woźniak [70]; Bartłomiejski Kowalewsk [49]; Asmussen, J. [71].	Representations and images of port cities. Urban development.

Recent debate has focused on the specificity and reach of this supposed new field within sociology, as well as discussion on its epistemological status, for instance, Longo [9] insists on embedding it into environmental sociology, but at the same time, they debate on its conceptual definition. While there are other authors who advocate for a maritime sociology [14], but also sociology of the ocean [25] enters the debate and blue sociology [72] is also being developed at the same time. In the case of academic events that point out to accelerate the production of research in the area, we find the Workshop on Fisheries Sociology, made in the middle of the 1980 decade, in which the lack of academic projects such as journals, a society, annual meetings, or any other initiative to consolidate this subfield on marine sociology is made explicit. In the case of fisheries, fisheries sociology doesn't remain stable through time, and calls made to institutionalize the subfield are retaken as a research table dedicated, this time, to "maritime sociology" in the 2015, 2019 and 2021 versions of the European Sociological Association (ESA), as well as through the organization of the Conference "Sociology at Sea: Culture, Economy and Society in a Maritime Perspective" in 2013 and other national congresses such as the ad hoc group on marine sociology for the national congress of the German Sociological Association in Treveris, 2014 in which experiences were exchanged between Polish and German scholars and the Polish congress of sociology organized in September 2022 in Warsaw, Poland.

Despite the conceptual and epistemological differences, it is necessary, and the same way as happens with sustainability science, to acknowledge pluralism without falling in epistemological relativism of the approaches and analytical tools that addresses the object of study of maritime sociology. Thus, we recognize the fruitful results from the diversity of studies that apply analytical tools from sociology to the marine space and their problems, and at the same time, we invite to avoid the pernicious results from fragmenting the definition of this subfield of sociology and fall in isolated studies, without connection with attempts to consolidate a proposal for maritime sociology.

2.2. Contributions of sociological thought to transitions towards sustainability

In the current panorama, forecasted by the UN decade of action, with the predominant economic order, society walks a path of unsustainability towards ecological disasters, thus, a transition, a “change” towards sustainability is one of the stated goals of sustainability research. Nevertheless, this change is complex given the intricate web of power, cultural, social, economic interests, and cognitive schemes (that very often leads to an inertia in the behavior of people) that usually goes in opposite directions, tensioning any type of arrangement towards sustainability. There has been an increasing concern on the role of conflict. In this sense, transitions toward sustainability implies “social change” a paramount concept with several decades of evolution in sociological research and literature where power, justice, social struggle, and cultural issues have been deeply analyzed and discussed. Only recently, sociologists, sustainability and environmental researchers have started to work on frameworks on social-ecological changes or social-ecological transitions. Current frameworks stemming from social-ecological systems have been criticized for lacking sensitivity to social and power inequalities or lacking historical perspective, sometimes seeing social agents as a sum of ahistorical, rationally driven individuals devoid of culture or power differentials [73–76]. It is here where sociological perspectives are starting to appear and provide significant insights into these issues, however a deeper integration is needed. For instance, the model of social-ecological transitions [3] includes the “social-political shock” as a catalyst for potential social change towards sustainability, as well as concepts such as “social memory”, “awareness of need for change”, “social learning”, “informal social institutions", “political leaderships”, “power”, etc. The current trends show that social field theories are starting to be used and integrated into some of these frameworks [5,22] with positive results, providing insights for social-ecological systems to a more nuanced view of complex social relationships.

3. Discussion and conclusion

We briefly discussed some recent debates on sociology and sustainability science and maritime research, as well as developments on the consolidation of this new subfield of maritime sociology and rising debates on sociology and social-ecological transformations and transitions to sustainability. Based on the reviewed literature, there is a consensus that sociology has a lot to offer for sustainability science, both in terms of theories, approaches, and body of literature, however, it is acknowledged that sociology is sub-utilized in the context of sustainability research. This due to several reasons such as the dominant view of sociology as focused on terrestrial issues, where social relationships occurred on the ground and where what happens on and below the sea is an extension of terrestrial society, or because of the original division between sociology and anthropology, where sociology has been mainly concerned since it’s beginning to “modern” problems such as those based on more urban and industrialized societies and anthropology as the one concerned to most “traditional” economic activities such as in fisheries or transportation. We also discussed

some recent attempts from several authors and organizations to establish a new maritime sociology, however much discussion is appeared to be focused on epistemological and conceptual differences and not so much on practical applications of the rich toolbox of sociology, we argue for more focus on producing more applied research on maritime sociology and not to fragmentate this new subfield and, finally, we review the most recent research on the role of sociology in new theoretical frameworks of social change towards sustainability, where progress has been made to integrate more sociological notions into sustainability research.

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This research on artisanal fishers from China relate the notion of social-ecological resilience with the contemporary sociological theoretical framework of actor-network theory.

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A synthesis of empirical evidence on how woman experience, shape, and influence governance of marine resources in artisanal fisheries.

62. Bennett NJ, Blythe J, White CS, Campero C**. Blue growth and blue justice: Ten risks and solutions for the ocean economy.** Marine Policy [Internet]. 2021 Mar [cited 2023 Oct 15];125:104387. Available from: https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S0308597X20310381 *

In the face of the risks associated with blue growth, ten types of social injustices are analyzed in relation with this type of growth. It ends with an important discussion on future paths to a more just and integrating oceanic economy.

63. Ertör I. '**We are the oceans, we are the people!': fisher people's struggles for blue justice.** The Journal of Peasant Studies [Internet]. 2023 Apr 16 [cited 2023 Oct 15];50(3):1157–86. Available from: https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/03066150.2021.1999932 *

A landmark study where 120 fishers' conflicts were analyzed, especially small-scale fisheries where artisanal fishers experience a series of injustices by coastal and high seas investment and economic inequalities in marine capitalist economy. Such conflicts are identified and mapped into the Atlas for Environmental Justice. Blue justice is proposed as theoretical framework.

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72. Picken F. Oceans, Space and Society: towards a Blue Sociology [Internet]. MacMillan; Preprint. Available from: http://www.academia.edu/9098567/Oceans_Space_and_Society_Towards_a_Blue_Sociology_with_Palgrave_MacMillan_

73. May CK. **Complex adaptive governance systems: a framework to understand institutions, organizations, and people in socio-ecological systems**. Socio Ecol Pract Res [Internet]. 2022 Mar [cited 2023 Oct 15];4(1):39–54. Available from: https://link.springer.com/10.1007/s42532-021-00101-7 *

An important effort towards the development of a framework that gather governance and social-ecological systems. The complex adaptive governance systems focus on institutions, organizations and actors affected by social-ecological practices and processes and vindicate social sciences contributions to sustainability.

74. Béné C, Doyen L. From Resistance to Transformation: A Generic Metric of Resilience Through Viability. Earth's Future [Internet]. 2018 Jul [cited 2023 Oct 15];6(7):979–96. Available from: https://agupubs.onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/2017EF000660

75. Fabinyi M, Evans L, Foale SJ. Social-ecological systems, social diversity, and power: insights from anthropology and political ecology. E&S [Internet]. 2014 [cited 2023 Mar 4];19(4):art28. Available from: http://www.ecologyandsociety.org/vol19/iss4/art28/

76. Béné C. Are we messing with people's resilience? Analysing the impact of external interventions on community intrinsic resilience. International Journal of Disaster Risk Reduction [Internet]. 2020 Apr [cited 2023 Oct 15];44:101431. Available from: https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S2212420919309379

Reviewers	Observations	Changes included or/and comments to the reviewers.
Reviewer I	1. Abstract: The abstract is quite weak. It is made up of very long 3 sentences and lacks any real detail about what the research has actually found. For example, what are the current developments in sociology that are being referred to? What are important and recent contributions in maritime research to sociology? Overall, the abstract is quite vague and doesn't really tell the reader very much about the paper.	The abstract has been modified to be more concise and to provide the essential information regarding its importance and main conclusions.
	2. “IU found that the paper lacks any real consideration of the emerging community of active marine social science researchers which has been developing over the last 5 to 10 years”.	We incorporated this observation and included the contributions of current marine social sciences production. For example, we included the manifesto for marine social sciences, the 2019 MARE. Additionally, we highlight that the objective of the paper is not to work with marine social science as an epistemic community, rather, is to specifically discuss the case of sociology, which hasn’t been developed in the same way as economics or marine anthropology (figure 2). It is true that marine social sciences exist as a community or epistemic field (figure 1), there isn’t a similar production from sociology. In fact, from the 50 documents analyzed in Scopus and WOS databases, only one document explicitly mentions sociology in the abstract.

	3. While I don't disagree that there is a need to think about developing marine sociology research, IU found that the paper lacks any real consideration of the emerging community of active marine social science researchers which has been developing over the last 5 to 10 years.	We re-worked the introduction to make it clearer and more explicit that this analysis is not focused on marine social sciences, we agree that there is a flourishing and active community (or field, in a more Bourdiesian perspective); rather, we focused on specific contributions from sociology.
	4. "27: there are a number of papers that could be cited here - including from Claudet et al., 2021; Germond-Duret et al., 2023; Popova et al., 2021 and more. This whole section would benefit from more engagement with the wider literature on this topic. 32: The Ocean Decade should be named in full here, with relevant citations. 38: Could you include a definition of how you are using 'sociology' in the context of this paper, please?"	The following contributions were included in the text and table 1: • Spalding A, Suman D. Oceans and Society: An Introduction to Marine Studies [Internet]. 1st ed. London: Routledge; 2023 [cited 2023 Oct 13]. Available from: https://www.taylorfrancis.com/books/9781003058151 • Bennett NJ. Marine Social Science for the Peopled Seas. Coastal Management [Internet]. 2019 Mar 4 [cited 2024 Apr 27];47(2):244–52. Available from: https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/08920753.2019.1564958 • McKinley E, Acott T, Yates KL. Marine social sciences: Looking towards a sustainable future. Environmental Science & Policy [Internet]. 2020 Jun [cited 2024 Apr 27];108:85–92. Available from: https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S1462901119312961 • Pelke N, Simonn FC. Ocean-human relations in the Anthropocene: mapping trends in sustainability-related marine social sciences articles. Front Mar Sci [Internet]. 2023 Aug 18 [cited 2024 Apr 27];10:1210133. Available from: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fmars.2023.1210133/full • McKinley E, Kelly R, Mackay M, Shellock R, Cvitanovic C, Van Putten I. Development and expansion in the marine social sciences: Insights from

		the global community. iScience [Internet]. 2022 Aug [cited 2024 Apr 27];25(8):104735. Available from: https://linkinghub.elsevier.com/retrieve/pii/S2589004222010070 • Popova E, Aksenov Y, Amoudry LO, Becker A, Bricheno L, Brown JM, et al. Socio-oceanography: an opportunity to integrate marine social and natural sciences. Front Mar Sci [Internet]. 2023 Aug 14 [cited 2024 Apr 27];10:1209356. Available from: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/fmars.2023.1209356/full In the third paragraph we mention that we are using sociology (and sociological concepts) from a relational perspective as stated by Kungl G & Hess DJ (2021), highlighting the contributions from sociological debates on social relations, social change, agency, and institutions.
	5. "Is this literature search part of the methodology? It seems very strange for it to be in the introduction section. Could this be added and redefined as a methods section please?"	We provide a description of the search strategy for clarification and transparency, however as a "current opinion" we focus on comment on recent literature on a specific topic, in this type of text, a methodology section is not strictly required.
	6. References: Why are there descriptions and comments about the papers under some of the references? These should be removed.	The comments and marks on the references are a special feature of the journal, they are made with the intent of guide readers to relevant and recent literature on the topic
	7. Overall, I found the paper to be quite weak - it was not really clear to me what the paper was trying to propose to the reader. There is not real evaluation of how sociology can contribute to marine science, or what the next steps might be to move this area of research forward. There are no recommendations as to how maritime sociology contributes to sustainability science, or what areas of research	We rephrase and clarify in the fourth paragraph our objectives. We propose a hypothesis on the scarce visibility of the subfield of maritime sociology, identify in table 1 the different research lines for a possible maritime sociology. Finally, in the last section, we discuss the contributions of this possible new subfield to transitions to sustainability under the theoretical framework of sustainability science.

	might be. I am not sure what the contribution of this paper is and how it adds to the existing literature base.	
Reviewer II	1. The problem of defining what maritime sociology is quite long. Personally, I think that there are two main directions in the development of maritime sociology: (1) related to the sociology of profession (work) - studies of sailors and fishermen, and within the framework of (2) environmental sociology. 2. It should be known that the area of sociological work in the first area (sociology of sea people) is today, if not very large, then at least large. 3. The second area is perhaps slightly less developed in terms of research, but here too (if we add studies on the port city) there are many sociological considerations.	We included the contributions of sociology of work and professions (included within the topic of industrialization and port cities). We also included some of the Works published in the “Annal of Maritime Sociology” (Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej), polish academic journal, influenced by the works of Janiszewski).
Reviewer III	4. The methodological strategy mentioned, including a specific Scopus search command, contains a typographical error that should be corrected for accuracy. I am not aware of such a command in Scopus as "TITLE-ABS-KEY KEY." I confirmed the result by using the command: TITLE-ABS-KEY ("maritime sociology" OR "marine sociology" OR "blue sociology" OR "sociology of oceans" OR "fish* sociology"). I think this is a typo to be corrected.	The typo was removed "TITLE-ABS-KEY"
	5. Lines 11-12 suggest a specific timeframe (2005 to 2023) for a Scopus search strategy, which might imply a significant event in 2005. Clarification	Exactly, the timeframe was the direct result of the Scopus database. Additionally, we included the WOS database for every search and maintained the timeframes without changes. We dropped the search “sustainability science” AND “sociology” (TITLE-ABS-KEY), and focused on two searches: (1) A search on the notion of

	is needed to avoid misunderstanding; it appears this timeframe was merely the result of the search query. I think this detail is worth specifying, so that the reader does not get the impression that something spectacularly important happened in 2005 - which is what made the Authors decide on this time frame.	marine social sciences and (2) the following search strategy: (“maritime sociology” OR “marine sociology” OR “blue sociology” OR “sociology of oceans” OR “sociology of the sea” OR “sociology of fish*” OR “fish* sociology” (TITLE-ABS-KEY).
	6. As I read the article, I wonder whether the authors have verified the results of the Scopus search with whether the articles are actually in the area of maritime sociology and its related fields. Citing Scopus is important in that it gives some vouch for objectivity, but its results are in this case a bit fudged. The search during ESA is very important because of the dispersion of publications devoted to the field of maritime sociology and their multilingualism - but it is very circumstantial. A substantive gain would have been if the search had been enriched with other sources, e.g. Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej' (https://www.journals.pan.pl/rsm/). But this is not a necessary demand	We considered this a very important observation given its importance for this subfield, that’s why we broadened the search to the Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej journal of the Polish Academy of Sciences. Some of the articles identified in the formula “maritime sociology” were described in Table 1. For more detail, the two last rows of the table include these contributions to maritime sociology.
	7. Last comments: * I suggest thinking about adding criteria. TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability" AND "sociology" AND "ocean") returns 11 papers, while TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability" AND "sociology" AND "sea") returns 17 papers, TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability" AND "sociology" AND "maritime") returns 2 papers, TITLE-ABS-KEY ("environmental sociology" AND	We agree with the reviewer’s comment, we acknowledge that the contributions from maritime sociology are spread and are embedded in environmental sociology. However, in this current opinion we search for specific contributions towards a possible subfield of maritime sociology within the discipline (regardless this subfield may be embedded in environmental sociology). We search for more than the application of sociological tools to marine “objects” of study. However, we included the formula with two new criteria “sociology of the sea” OR “sociology of fish*”

	"sea") returns 7 papers. The last suggestion stems from what we observed on the Research Stream "Maritime Sociology" at the ESA Congress. Namely, that the growth of interest in the human/nature/environment relationship in sociology, has resulted in environmental sociology. There were also a number of convergent articles published in this discipline that could have been in the area of maritime sociology - but due to the niche nature of 'maritime sociology' in sociology, they were associated with the more recognisable sub-discipline of environmental sociology. In the context of sustainable development it is worth mentioning I think (without necessarily adding the criteria mentioned above).	
	8. I have my doubts as to why the Authors decided to use the formula TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability science" AND "sociology") and not TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability" AND "sociology"), where we get 1364 results from 1989 - 2024. The explanation that sustainability science is an "umbrela term" turns out to be untrue or wishful thinking at this point in the compilation.	We removed the two searches TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability science" AND "sociology") and TITLE-ABS-KEY ("sustainability" AND "sociology"). We deleted the idea of sustainability science as an “umbrella term”. We provide a better description of sustainability science in paragraph 1.
	9. Maritime sociology as a research area in Poland was established around Ludwik Janiszewski's theory of marinization. It is worth remembering that since the 1970s, it was concerned with five basic categories of the sea's impact on society: direct physical impact exerted by the sea, impact on the psyche (imagination, emotions,	We included the work from Ludwik Janiszewski. Once we broadened the scope of our search, we included more of his contributions, as well as the contributions from the Polish researchers. We acknowledged his contributions in paragraph 8: “*These efforts to avoid terracentrism in the discipline [31] by recognizing sociologists contributions to build a possible maritime sociology [32], some of which re-discovered the work of Norbert Elias [33] and Ludwik Janiszewski’s concept of “maritimization” (the social impacts of the sea) in the field of global relation [34,35], and contribute an ontological and epistemological reflection on the sea and oceans,*

	worldview) which was to be reflected in the consciousness of people living in coastal areas, impact on the economic life of coastal ecological units impact of the sea on migratory movements, impact of the sea on the ecosystem. Thus, marinization was a process that took place on an objective (natural) as well as subjective (consciousness) level. And here comes the issue of limiting the Scopus search engine to English-language, Western journals and publications, which suggest that the only founding father is Michael Poole, and not elsewhere cited also contemporaries Ludwik Janiszewski and his concept of the theory of marinization, around which maritime sociology was founded in Poland, and today continues to be a source of inspiration (see: Kolodziej A. (2012), The Concept of Marinization by Ludwik Janiszewski -To Understand the Influence of the Sea).	*labeled "blue turn" or "oceanic turn" [8,36,37]. Notably, Poland has actively developed maritime sociology (heavily influenced by Janiszewski), even establishing a dedicated journal called "Annal of Maritime Sociology" (Roczniki Socjologii Morskiej). As the concept started relatively new, its development has been concentrated in Great Britain, Scandinavian countries, China and Eastern Europe [14,25,38]."*
	1. En la frase: "has been observed that the marine ecosystem has been mostly ignored by sociology [8,9]"	We included a recent source to support our claims: • Cocco, E., & Diodati, E. (2024). Ripensare la Ocean Governance. La gestione degli spazi marittimi nella prospettiva della "sociologia blu." Rivista Trimestrale Di Scienza Dell'Amministrazione Studi Di Teoria e Ricerca Sociale. https://doi.org/10.32049/RTSA.2024.1.08
	2. While I don't disagree that there is a need to think about developing marine sociology research, IU found that the paper lacks any real consideration of the emerging community of active marine social science researchers which has	We included two figures to highlight the lack of protagonism from sociology in marine research. From one hand, in his role within marine social sciences and on the other hand, compared to the development in other fields such as economics (for example the blue economy).

	been developing over the last 5 to 10 years	